Lesson 02: Pronunciation: Syllables and Word Stress

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): 1.3: Counting Syllables; 1.4: Syllable Stress.

In this lesson

You will learn what a syllable is and count the syllables in words, many of them from the Berlin video. Then you will learn that in words with two or more syllables, one syllable is stronger than the others. You will practice hearing and saying this word stress, and you will record yourself.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what a syllable is.
- Count the syllables in a word and divide the word into syllables.
- Find the stressed syllable in words with two, three and four syllables.
- Use a dictionary to check the number of syllables and the stress.
- Say words from this unit with the correct stress.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
syllable	a part of a word with one vowel sound	ba·na·na has 3 syllables
vowel sound	the sound at the center of each syllable	"eat" has two vowel letters but one vowel sound
consonant sound	a sound like /t/, /s/ or /k/; most syllables have one or more	sit = /s/ + vowel + /t/
word stress	the strongest syllable in a word	re·PEAT
stressed syllable	the strong syllable: long, with a clear vowel	"PEAT" in re·PEAT
unstressed syllable	a weak syllable: short and unclear	"re" in re·PEAT
schwa /ə/ as in "about"	the short, weak vowel in many unstressed syllables	a·BOUT
stress mark [']	in a dictionary, the mark before the stressed syllable	'pre·sent, pre·'sent
one-syllable words	words with one vowel sound	sit, cook, eat
two-syllable words	words with two vowel sounds	cit·y, cook·ie, eat·ing

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
three-syllable words	words with three vowel sounds	beau·ti·ful, ba·na·na, eas·i·ly

Rules and explanations

Syllables

- We divide words into syllables to help us pronounce words clearly.
- Each syllable has **only one vowel sound**. It usually has one or more consonant sounds too.
- Count vowel **sounds**, not vowel letters. "eat" has two vowel letters (e, a) but one vowel sound, so it has one syllable. "vibe" has one vowel sound (the e is silent), so it also has one syllable.
- Words can have one, two, three or more syllables: sit (1), cit·y (2), beau·ti·ful (3), wa·ter·mel·on (4).

Word stress

- In words with two or more syllables, one syllable is stronger than the others. It has the most stress (emphasis).
- The stressed syllable is **long**, and its vowel is **clear**.
- The other syllables are **short and unclear**. Their vowel is often the schwa /ə/ as in "about".
- Each word has only one syllable with the main (primary) stress.
- Book examples (CAPITALS = stress):
  - two syllables: AP·ple, re·PEAT, SEV·en
  - three syllables: LA·dy·bug, de·LI·cious, un·der·STAND
  - four syllables: WA·ter·mel·on, av·o·CA·do, a·BIL·i·ty

One spelling, two stress patterns

Some words change stress when they change meaning:

- PRE·sent (noun): People usually give a present for birthdays and weddings.
- pre·SENT (verb): The scientists will present their research.

Checking words yourself

- **Dictionary:** most dictionaries put the mark ['] before the stressed syllable. Try the Merriam-Webster Learner's Dictionary: https://learnersdictionary.com/
- **How Many Syllables:** https://www.howmanysyllables.com/ Type the word, find the number of syllables, find the stress, then play the recording and say the word.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Standard Arabic does not start a syllable with two consonants, so learners sometimes add a short vowel: "scratch" can sound like "is-cratch" or "se-cratch". This adds a syllable. Say s-c-r together: "scratch" has only one syllable. - Arabic stress usually follows fixed rules, but English stress often does not. Learn the stress together with each new word, and check it in the dictionary.

Practice

The audio clips for exercises 7, 9 and 10 are in the attachments folder for 1.4 Syllable Stress on your computer (folder "01.04-syllable-stress"), or on the original web page.

1. Answer the questions. a) How many vowel sounds are in each syllable? (one / two / three) b) How many consonants are usually in each syllable? (only one / one or more)

2. Count the syllables (Practice 1). Watch the "Syllables" video first (link below). Then write 1, 2, 3 or 4 for each word: cat, scratch, ball, acorn, seven, watermelon, dog, apple, ladybug, salamander, garden, unicorn, spectacles, elephant, invisible, January

3. Count the syllables (Practice 2). These words are from the Berlin video: market, neighborhood, galleries, exude, vibe, curry, powder, concoction, sausage, symbol

4. Divide the words into syllables. Write the number of syllables, then divide the word. Example: memorial – 4 – me-mor-i-al graffiti, infamous, dangle, unity, escape, wild, deer, hangout, vintage

5. Think of your own words. Write two different words for each group.

- one syllable (example: desk)
- two syllables (example: pencil)
- three syllables (example: choc·o·late; dictionaries differ: they give 2 syllables, choc·late)

6. Recording 1: read part of the transcript. Watch the Berlin video (link below) and read the transcript in your printed lesson: only the introduction and places 1 and 2. Look up new words. Practice reading aloud at a normal speed (not too fast). Record yourself with your phone, listen, check for mistakes, and record again. Then read it to your tutor and ask which words were unclear.

7. Stress in two-syllable words. First play "Syllable_Stress_Recording" and repeat the book's examples in the Rules section (AP·ple, re·PEAT, SEV·en ...). Then watch Rachel's English, "Word Stress in Two-Syllable Words" (link below). Write each word with the stressed syllable in capitals. Example: re·PEAT about, daughter, sleepy, unreal, question, relax, rely, quiet, perfect, allow, standard, delete

8. Stress in three-syllable words. Watch Rachel's English, "Word Stress in Three-Syllable Words" (link below). Example: com·PU·ter rational, popular, decided, example, everyday, eighty-one, sensation

9. Stress quiz. Play "Syllable_Stress_Quiz". You will hear each word two times. Write each word with the strongest (stressed) syllable in capitals. Listen as many times as you need. bursting, excited, memorial, dangle, escape, graffiti, dividing, covered, infamously, kilometer, explain, concoction, curry, powder, popular, delicious, present (noun), present (verb)

10. Recording 2. Play "Syllable_Stress_Recording_Task". Then say words 1 to 16 from exercise 9 (bursting to delicious). Make the stressed vowel long and clear. Make the other vowels quick, usually with a schwa sound. Record yourself, listen, and give yourself one point for each correct word: _____ / 16.

Speak with your tutor

- "I will say a word from this lesson. Tell me how many syllables you heard and which syllable I stressed."
- "Give me five new words with two or three syllables. I will guess the stress, and you tell me if I am right."
- "Listen to me read the start of the transcript of '25 Things to do in Berlin'. Tell me which words I said unclearly."
- "Ask me about a present I liked as a child. Then ask me to present my favorite place in my city. Check that I say PRE·sent and pre·SENT correctly."
- "Say a word two times, once with the right stress and once with the wrong stress. I will tell you which one is correct."

Read aloud

1. ba·NA·na
2. de·LI·cious
3. un·der·STAND
4. av·o·CA·do
5. a·BIL·i·ty
6. me·MO·ri·al
7. con·COC·tion
8. People usually give a PRE·sent for birthdays and weddings. (↘)
9. The scientists will pre·SENT their research. (↘)

Watch online

- Syllables: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9S7DY2lgJlU
- Rachel's English, Word Stress in Two-Syllable Words: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gEpYBLjrO6s
- Rachel's English, Word Stress in Three-Syllable Words: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=08qBN29mIBs
- 25 Things to do in Berlin (for Recording 1): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lw5NHQeXzpA

Answer key

1. (book) a) one b) one or more
2. (book) cat 1, scratch 1, ball 1, acorn 2, seven 2, watermelon 4, dog 1, apple 2, ladybug 3, salamander 4, garden 2, unicorn 3, spectacles 3, elephant 3, invisible 3 (dictionaries differ: they give 4, in·vis·i·ble), January 3 (dictionaries differ: they give 4, Jan·u·ar·y). The book gives no answer for "dog"; the dictionary gives 1.
3. (book) market 2, neighborhood 3, galleries 3, exude 2, vibe 1, curry 2, powder 2, concoction 3, sausage 2, symbol 2
4. graffiti 3 graf·fi·ti; infamous 3 in·fa·mous; dangle 2 dan·gle; unity 3 u·ni·ty; escape 2 es·cape; wild 1 wild; deer 1 deer; hangout 2 hang·out; vintage 2 vin·tage
5. (example answer) one: park, wall; two: garden, market; three: elephant, popular
6. (example answer) Check these words in your recording: burst·ing (2), ex·ci·ted (3), me·mo·ri·al (4), graf·fi·ti (3), cen·tu·ry (3), ki·lo·me·ter (4).
7. (book) a·BOUT, DAUGH·ter, SLEEP·y, un·REAL, QUES·tion, re·LAX, re·LY, QUI·et, PER·fect, al·LOW, STAN·dard, de·LETE. Note: PER·fect is the adjective (a perfect day). The verb "to perfect" is per·FECT.
8. (book) RA·tion·al, POP·u·lar, de·CI·ded, ex·AM·ple, ev·ery·DAY (dictionaries differ: many give EV·ery·day), eigh·ty-ONE, sen·SA·tion
9. (book) BURST·ing, ex·CI·ted, me·MO·ri·al, DAN·gle, es·CAPE, graf·FI·ti, di·VID·ing, COV·ered, IN·fa·mous·ly (check), ki·LO·me·ter (some speakers also say KIL·o·me·ter), ex·PLAIN, con·COC·tion, CUR·ry, POW·der, POP·u·lar, de·LI·cious, PRE·sent (noun), pre·SENT (verb)
10. The same as answers 1 to 16 in exercise 9.

My notes